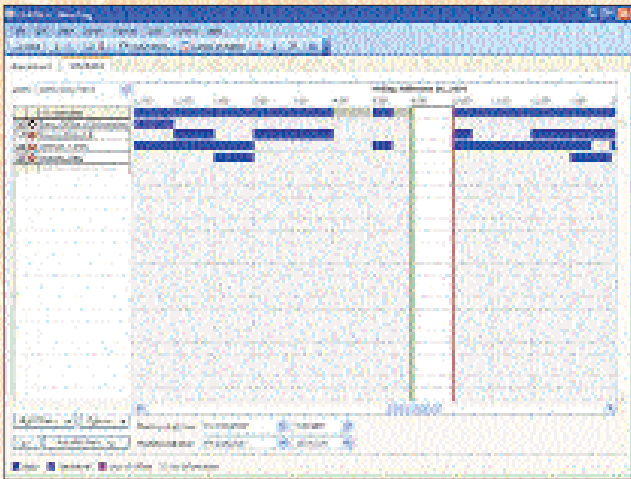




Set up meetings when everyone's free

But...

The problem with Exchange Server is that it's expensive. At \$67 (Rs 3,000) per license, it seems like more of a luxury for a small organisation, unless everything has plunged into chaos. In the past year or so, we've seen the emergence of open source alternatives to Exchange, and while they don't mimic all the features, they do get the essentials right.

Each of the suites you'll encounter comes with all the caveats of open source software—specifically, iffy free support. If you do decide to go in this direction, we recommend coughing up the extra money for a supported version. In fact, the developers have presented the products as paid software with an optional GPL licensed version.

Open-Xchange Server

www.open-xchange.com

Open-Xchange is one of the more promising Exchange alternatives available today. It works in every situation that Exchange does, including with Palm- and Windows Mobile-based PDAs, and adds a few more features on top. Depending on the size of your organisation, you'll end up paying license fees starting from \$30 (Rs 1,350) per user to as little as \$25 (Rs 1,125)—not exactly cheap, but less than half the price of Exchange Server.

It also runs only on Linux, so you'll have to set up a Red Hat or SuSE Server to run it (other distributions are fine, too, but Open-Xchange officially supports the aforementioned two). If you're worried about the skills required, fret not—Open-Xchange has a fairly easy-to-understand administration interface.

To get Outlook and other devices or software working with Open-Xchange, you'll first have to download the respective OXtender plugin; not a particularly palatable act, but it's one of the compromises you have to make when forsaking Microsoft Exchange.

Once you've got the OXtender, Outlook integrates with Open-Xchange quite seamlessly, even updating itself automatically. On the other hand, you don't get to keep your existing Outlook folders—the OXtender creates its set of

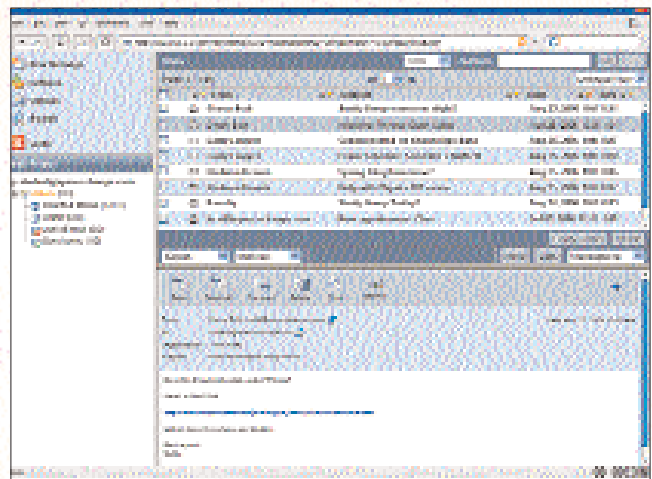
Open-Xchange inbox.

You can get yourself a live demo of the Open-Xchange Web interface at www.open-xchange.com/footer/downloads/openx-change_onlinedemo.html (the server isn't always responsive, however); this will give you an idea of the features it gives you. We're quite impressed with the project management part—these solutions are usually made for software developers, but the ability to add your own custom fields to a project makes it easier to adapt to your own specific needs. Finally, it features Infostore—a knowledge base where you can store documents for everyone to access.

The Community Angle

If you want to try out Open-Xchange, you can download the Open-Xchange Community Edition free of cost. This open source edition is mainly for developers who intend to contribute to the project, but if you've got the time and skill, you can set it up as a long-term solution in your office as well.

You're not left to fend for yourself, thankfully—Open-Xchange has been extensively documented on the wiki (wiki.open-xchange.com), and there are a bunch of step-by-step



Open-Xchange's Web interface keeps you in touch with the office

guides to help you on your way. There's also a forum for you to share ideas and problems with the community.

Plunge

Even for an organisation with as little as twenty people, having this collaboration setup will prove invaluable. Nearly everyone uses Outlook at work, so the environment is as friendly as can be. You can access your collaboration tools from anywhere as well, just as long as you have Internet access.

For smaller organisations, even using the open source edition is fine, but if you have luck like ours, you'll inevitably be faced with a problem that befuddles both you and the rest of the community. If you and/or a minion has the skill to save the day in such a scenario, well and good—if not, stick to the paid version. ■

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